

# Classic Fables

Ten text-only retellings

# **The Boy Who Cried Wolf**

On the slope above a small village, a young shepherd spent each day watching a flock of sheep. The work was quiet. The sheep cropped grass, the clouds moved slowly, and the only sounds were bells, wind, and the boy's own thoughts. At first he enjoyed the freedom. After several long afternoons, however, the silence began to feel like a cage. He wished for something exciting to happen.

One day he ran down the hill, waving his arms and shouting, "Wolf! Wolf! Please help me!" The villagers dropped their tools and hurried up the path with sticks and stones. They expected to find a wild animal among the sheep, but there was no wolf at all. The boy laughed at their worried faces. A few villagers scolded him, yet he only smiled, pleased that the hill had become lively for a while.

A few days later, boredom returned. Remembering how quickly everyone had come, the boy cried out again. Once more the villagers rushed to his aid. Once more they found nothing. This time their faces were less frightened than angry. An old farmer told the boy that a warning was a promise: when someone heard it, they trusted it enough to leave their own work behind. The boy nodded, but he did not truly listen.

Near sunset one evening, a real wolf crept from the trees. It moved low through the grass, its eyes fixed on the sheep. The boy's throat tightened. He shouted louder than he had ever shouted before. "Wolf! Wolf! This time it is real!" The villagers heard him, but each remembered the two tricks. They stayed by their homes, thinking he wanted another laugh.

The wolf scattered the flock before the shepherd could drive it away. When the boy returned to the village with only a few sheep, he wept and tried to explain. The old farmer did not speak harshly. He simply said, "People may forgive a lie, but trust does not always return at once." From then on, the boy learned that words can be useful like a bell or a rope, but only when people know they can rely on them.

# The Fox and the Grapes

On a warm afternoon, a fox wandered along a country lane looking for something to eat. He had searched beneath hedges and around fallen logs without much luck. At last he came to a vineyard surrounded by a low stone wall. Beyond it hung bunches of grapes, dark and shining in the sunlight. They looked cool, sweet, and exactly what he wanted after the dusty walk.

The fox found a gap in the wall and slipped inside. He stood beneath the nearest vine, measured the distance with his eyes, and sprang upward. His paws caught only air. He tried again from a small rock, then from a running start. Each leap brought him close enough to smell the fruit, but never close enough to bite it. The grapes swayed just above his nose.

A sparrow sitting on the wall watched quietly. "Perhaps another way around the vine would help," she suggested. The fox pretended not to hear. He did not like being observed while he failed. He searched for a taller stone, but it crumbled beneath his weight. He tried shaking the vine, but the bunches were tied high and strong. His cleverness, which usually pleased him, seemed useless that day.

After many attempts, the fox was tired and embarrassed. He looked once more at the grapes and said loudly, "They are probably sour anyway. I would not want them." Then he walked away with his tail held high. The sparrow watched him go and wondered why he had not simply admitted that the fruit was beyond his reach.

Later, the fox found blackberries growing close to the ground. They were not as grand as the grapes, but they were ripe and sweet. As he ate, he thought about the vineyard. He realized that calling the grapes sour had not made them any less desirable; it had only protected his pride for a moment. From then on, he tried to say, "I could not get it today," instead of pretending he had never wanted it. Honest disappointment, he discovered, leaves more room to learn.

# The Ant and the Grasshopper

During the bright days of summer, an ant worked from morning until evening. She carried seeds, crumbs, and dry grains through a narrow path to her underground storehouse. The work was steady rather than dramatic, but every trip added a little more to the pile. Her neighbors often saw her pass and asked why she never rested in the sun.

A grasshopper nearby spent his days singing from a tall blade of grass. He loved the heat, the music of insects, and the easy meals he found in the meadow. When he saw the ant carrying another seed, he laughed kindly. "Summer is made for dancing," he said. "Why worry about cold days when the sky is so blue?" The ant paused long enough to answer, "Because the blue sky will not last forever." Then she returned to her work.

The grasshopper invited her to join his songs. Sometimes the ant wished she could. Yet she remembered last winter, when frost had covered the field and food had been difficult to find. She did not work because she disliked happiness. She worked so that future hardship would not take away every choice. By the end of summer, her storeroom was full, and she allowed herself a quiet evening of rest.

Autumn arrived with cooler winds. The grasshopper kept singing, but the grass became dry and the insects disappeared. Soon snow covered the meadow. Hungry and shivering, he went to the ant's door. He expected anger, because he had mocked her effort. Instead, she gave him a warm meal. After he had eaten, she asked him what he would do differently when spring returned.

The grasshopper lowered his head. "I will still sing," he said, "but I will also prepare." The ant nodded. She showed him how to gather and store food, and he helped her repair a passage damaged by rain. When summer came again, the meadow heard the grasshopper's music as before. But between songs, he worked beside the ants. He had learned that enjoyment and responsibility are not enemies; planning for tomorrow makes today's joy easier to keep.

## The Lion and the Mouse

A lion lay sleeping beneath a broad tree after a long hunt. The shade was cool, and his breathing was deep and slow. A small mouse, hurrying home through the roots, ran across the lion's paw. The lion woke at once and trapped the mouse beneath one huge claw. To the mouse, the claw looked like a falling hill.

"Please let me go," squeaked the mouse. "One day I may be able to help you." The lion began to laugh. He could not imagine how such a tiny creature could ever assist the king of the animals. Still, the mouse's fear touched him, and the day was peaceful. He lifted his paw and let her run away. The mouse disappeared into the grass, grateful and determined not to forget the kindness.

Several weeks later, the lion followed the smell of prey into a clearing where hunters had placed a strong rope net. Before he saw it, the net dropped over him. He roared and struggled, but every movement pulled the knots tighter. The forest shook with the sound, yet none of the larger animals dared approach the hunters' trap.

The mouse heard the roar from her nest. She recognized the voice of the lion who had spared her. Following the sound, she found him caught in the ropes. "Be still," she said. "I have small teeth, but they are sharp." The lion stopped struggling. The mouse gnawed one knot, then another, then another. It was slow work, and the lion had to wait with patience he had rarely needed before. At last a gap opened wide enough for him to push through.

Free again, the lion thanked the mouse with a bowed head. He understood that strength comes in many forms. The mouse had not fought the net with force; she had used the ability she possessed and the loyalty she had chosen to give. From that day, the lion no longer judged a creature's value by its size. And the mouse, though still small, walked through the forest knowing that even a quiet act of kindness can return in an unexpected hour.

# The Goose That Laid Golden Eggs

A farmer and his wife owned a goose that was unlike any other bird in the village. One morning, while gathering eggs, the farmer found a smooth, heavy egg gleaming in the straw. At first he thought someone had played a joke on him, but the gold was real. He sold the egg and brought home enough money to repair the roof and buy food for many weeks.

The next morning the goose laid another golden egg. Then another the day after that. The farmer and his wife became comfortable. They bought better clothes, filled their pantry, and spoke proudly of their good fortune. At first they treated the goose well, giving her clean water and fresh grain. But as they watched the small pile of coins grow, their minds turned from gratitude to impatience.

"Why must we wait one day at a time?" the farmer asked. "Surely the goose holds many golden eggs inside her." His wife was uneasy. "We have more than we once dreamed of," she said. "Let us be content." But the farmer imagined chests of gold and a life without waiting. Each morning's single egg began to feel smaller to him, even though nothing about it had changed.

At last greed overcame his judgment. Believing he could take all the golden eggs at once, he killed the goose. But inside he found only what any ordinary goose would have. There was no hidden treasure, no storehouse of gold, and no way to bring the bird back. The farmer stood in the quiet yard with empty hands.

For a long time, the couple had to live carefully again. The farmer often remembered the egg that had seemed too little only because he had started expecting too much. He learned that a steady gift can be more valuable than a sudden fortune, especially when it is cared for. The wife kept a simple clay bowl on the kitchen shelf as a reminder: enough is not a small thing. It is often the very thing that greed makes people fail to see.

# The Town Mouse and the Country Mouse

A country mouse lived beneath the floor of a quiet farmhouse. His meals were plain: grain, nuts, and pieces of cheese saved from the pantry. One autumn day his cousin from the town came to visit. The town mouse was neatly dressed and spoke of markets, kitchens, and houses with many rooms. When the country mouse set out his humble supper, the visitor tried to be polite but could not hide his surprise.

"You must come to town," said the visitor. "There are cakes, fruit, roasted meat, and cheese richer than anything here." The country mouse was curious, so the next morning they set off. In the town house, the country mouse stared at a table covered with wonderful food left after a feast. He tasted sweet crumbs, soft bread, and a piece of pear. For a moment he thought his cousin had been right: this was a grand life.

Suddenly a door opened. The mice fled beneath a cabinet as servants entered the room. When the servants left, the country mouse crept out again. He reached for another crumb, but a cat leaped from behind a chair. The cousins escaped through a crack in the wall, their hearts pounding. The town mouse sighed. "That happens sometimes," he said. "But the food is worth it."

The country mouse stayed another night, but he could not sleep. Every creak sounded like a footstep, every shadow looked like the cat. In the morning he thanked his cousin for the visit and began the journey home. Back at the farmhouse, he ate a dry grain beside the familiar wall. It was not luxurious, but he could hear the wind outside and know that no cat would spring from the dark.

The town mouse later visited the country and found the meals boring. The cousins understood then that neither life was perfect for everyone. One valued abundance and excitement; the other valued safety and peace. They stopped trying to persuade each other. The country mouse had learned that a simple meal enjoyed without fear can taste better than a feast guarded by danger, while the town mouse learned that comfort means different things to different hearts.

# The Crow and the Pitcher

During a long, dry summer, a crow flew across fields searching for water. The ponds had shrunk to mud, and the streams were thin. By afternoon his throat was dry and his wings felt heavy. At last he saw a pitcher standing beside an abandoned cottage. He landed beside it and looked inside. There was water at the bottom, clear and cool, but the narrow neck of the pitcher kept his beak from reaching it.

The crow tipped the pitcher with his claws, hoping to spill some water onto the ground. It was too heavy to move. He pushed, pulled, and flapped his wings against it, but the pitcher barely shifted. A young lizard watched from a stone nearby. "Perhaps it is impossible," the lizard said. The crow did not answer. He knew that giving up would not make his thirst disappear.

Near the pitcher lay several small pebbles. The crow picked one up and dropped it into the water. A tiny splash rose, and the water level lifted by almost nothing. He dropped another pebble, then another. The work was slow. Each stone seemed too small to matter, and the lizard soon grew tired of watching. But the crow noticed that the water had risen a little after every few stones.

He continued until the sun was low. The pitcher gradually filled with stones, and the water climbed toward its narrow mouth. At last it came close enough for the crow to drink. He took a long, grateful sip. The water had been there all along; what he needed was not greater strength, but a different idea and the patience to carry it out.

Before flying away, the crow looked at the remaining pebbles. He remembered how useless they had appeared when he first saw them. From that day, whenever he faced a difficult problem, he looked carefully at the small things nearby. A single small action may not solve a problem, but many thoughtful actions can change what once seemed impossible. The lizard, who had returned to see the result, carried that lesson with him as well.

## The Milkmaid and Her Pail

A young milkmaid named Mira balanced a pail of fresh milk on her head as she walked toward the market. The morning was cool, and the road was quiet except for birds in the hedges. Mira had been asked to sell the milk carefully and bring home the money. She knew the task was simple, yet it felt important; every drop in the pail was worth something to her family.

As she walked, Mira began to imagine what the money might become. "I will sell the milk and buy a basket of eggs," she thought. "The eggs will hatch into chickens. The chickens will lay more eggs, and I will sell those too." Her steps grew lighter. She pictured a small coop, then a flock, then enough money to buy a fine new dress for the spring festival.

The dream grew larger with every turn in the road. She imagined arriving at the festival in her new dress while the other young people admired it. She imagined someone making a foolish boast, and she imagined herself tossing her head proudly to show that she did not care. Without thinking, Mira gave her head a quick, proud shake.

The pail slipped. Milk spilled down her hair, across her dress, and into the dust of the road. For a moment Mira stood still, watching the white stream disappear into the earth. The eggs, chickens, flock, and festival dress vanished with it. She wanted to cry, but she also knew that none of those things had ever belonged to her. They had been plans built on a pail she had not yet delivered.

Mira returned home and told the truth. Her family was disappointed, but they helped her clean the pail and begin again the next day. This time she walked with one hand steadying the milk. She still had hopes, but she kept them gentle until her work was complete. Years later, she became known in the market as a careful trader. She would smile when young sellers spoke of grand profits and say, "Dream of tomorrow, but keep hold of what you carry today."

# The Wind and the Sun

The Wind and the Sun often argued about which of them was stronger. The Wind boasted that he could bend trees, raise waves, and scatter leaves across whole valleys. The Sun replied that strength was not always loud. One morning, they saw a traveler walking along the road wearing a thick cloak. The Wind proposed a contest: whoever could make the traveler remove his cloak would be declared stronger.

The Sun agreed to let the Wind try first. The Wind gathered himself and blew a sharp gust across the road. The traveler grabbed his cloak at the collar. The Wind blew harder, whistling between the trees and filling the road with dust. The traveler pulled the cloak tighter around his shoulders. Annoyed, the Wind became a storm. He shook branches and drove cold air beneath the cloak, but every blast made the traveler hold on more firmly.

At last the Wind grew tired and fell quiet. The Sun rose higher in the sky. He sent down warm light, first gently, then steadily. The traveler relaxed. The cold had passed, and the road felt pleasant. After a while, the traveler loosened the cloak. When the warmth continued, he took it off entirely and folded it over his arm.

The Wind frowned. "You did not force him," he said. The Sun answered, "No. I gave him a reason to choose." The Wind looked down the road and considered how his power had met resistance at every step. His blasts had been strong, but they had made the traveler defensive.

From then on, the two still had different natures. The Wind continued to sweep across mountains, and the Sun continued to warm fields. But the Wind remembered the traveler whenever he wanted to win an argument by force. He learned that gentleness can achieve what pressure cannot, because people often open when they feel safe and close themselves when they feel attacked. The Sun's quiet warmth had shown a kind of strength the Wind had not understood.

# **The Wolf in Sheep's Clothing**

A wolf lived near a hillside pasture where a shepherd guarded a large flock of sheep. The wolf watched from the trees and wanted an easy meal, but the shepherd's dogs barked whenever he came near. The sheep also scattered at the sight of him. After several failed attempts, the wolf understood that his own appearance warned everyone before he could get close.

One evening, the wolf found the fleece of a sheep caught on a thorn bush. He pulled it over his back and looked at himself in a pool of water. From a distance, he did resemble one of the flock. The next morning he walked slowly among the sheep with his head lowered. The shepherd saw only another woolly shape and did not notice the wolf's eyes beneath the fleece.

At first the plan seemed successful. The wolf came close to the flock, and the sheep did not run. He felt clever and proud. But pretending required constant care. He had to move slowly when he wanted to run, chew grass when he wanted meat, and stay silent when the dogs passed. Still, he waited for evening, when the shepherd would lead the sheep into the pen.

As dusk fell, the shepherd counted the flock. He noticed a large sheep he did not recognize and thought it would make a good meal for the next day's celebration. He took the disguised wolf into a separate stall. The wolf was pleased at first, believing he had been given a private chance to choose his prey. But when the shepherd returned carrying a rope, the wolf understood too late that he had deceived the wrong person.

The wolf escaped only by tearing free of the borrowed fleece and running into the forest. He lost both his disguise and his chance at the flock. The shepherd later found the fleece and realized what had happened. He became more careful when counting his animals, and the sheep learned to stay close to one another. The wolf learned a harsher lesson: a false appearance may fool others briefly, but it can also lead a deceiver into danger. Trust should be earned by honest conduct, not borrowed by costume.